

Poverty threatens agroforestry systems in Kaliro, Uganda

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Forests and agroforestry areas of Kaliro Uganda are on the decline. Local experts have in-depth knowledge about trends and hold important information that can lead to the identification of potential solutions. We held focus group discussions with local officials, community members and farmers to learn about the drivers of deforestation and potential solutions. These groups shared their impressions with us, that the loss of trees impacted local lives and livelihoods. Tree loss has led to locally declining rainfall, soil erosion, loss of soil fertility, declining crop harvests and subsequent food shortages. The loss of tree cover has also meant strong winds, more droughts and lower air quality. Without trees, fruits are in smaller quantities and varieties and firewood is harder to come by. Tree loss is driven by poverty and the need for charcoal and timber. Local people cut trees for firewood collection and expanding agricultural land (especially sugarcane). Building and road expansion and construction also drive tree loss. Country-wide peace and stability, together with good communication with traders and markets and improved road networks, increase the draw for tree products. Traders come from far and wide to collect tree products for outside markets. People in Kaliro appreciate the value of trees and are willing to plant, but do not have land to plant the trees on. They suggest interventions that ensure land rights, establish tree nurseries and supply accessible seedlings together with monitoring and advice. Supplying seedlings at the start of the rainy season will ensure that trees can be planted when there is plenty of rain and they can flourish. Continuous community sensitization and exemplary tree planting on parish and church land. Likewise, deterrents to cutting young trees and fruit trees could be effective, i.e. a cut and plant policy (cut 1 and plant 2).